persecution and oppression that the state and other political forces in Myanmar find harmony.

It is also worth noting that Rakhine was and is one of the poorest regions in Myanmar. It lacks the mineral wealth of other areas and is mostly reliant on fishing and agriculture (the port at Sittwe is the only major industrial conurbation). Locals interviewed by the author stressed that, as a result, there is a degree of prejudice among other Burmese groups who see Rakhine and the Rohingyas as being backward.[40] This in turn may explain why the Rakhine Buddhists are so ardent in arguing for their own 'superiority' over the Rohingyas, which is a driving factor in their persecution. In the rest of Myanmar, prejudice against the Rohingyas is common, but altogether relatively low key, and is really part and parcel of the wider anti-Muslim sentiment stirred up by the nationalist 969 Movement and other extremists.

All Burmese suffered when the 'Burmese Road to Socialism' proved to be an economic disaster[41] and 1988 saw a massive popular revolt that forced the generals to concede a return to democracy. New laws introduced in 1989 retained the discriminatory ethnicity laws from 1974, but a senior Rohingya official noted that the Rohingyas were still allowed to vote[42] in the 1990 elections and to stand for political parties[43]—either confessional parties or the military-backed National Unity Party or the new National League for Democracy. However, in a worrying sign of what was to come, the NLD (and its allies from the ethnic Rakhine community) tried to have Rohingya parliamentarians banned on the grounds that they must have used fake identity cards in order to stand for election.[44] Equally, renewed military attacks on the Rohingyas in 1991–2 saw a further 250,000 flee to Bangladesh and Malaysia.[45]

The military annulled the results of the 1990 elections and was able to hang on to power until 2008. At that stage a renewed popular revolt (the Saffron Revolution) and the impact of Cyclone Nargis[46] forced major changes. The 2008 Constitution[47] allowed for a return to a limited form of democracy but quite deliberately repeated the restrictive definition of citizenship from the 1974 legislation. Clearly the Rohingyas were to have no part in this democratic future.[48]

The run up to the 2015 elections completed this gradual process of destruction of the Rohingyas' civil rights. The 2014 census[49] forced them to